

Learning steps: On the Union Budget and education

India must further **strengthen** its investment in school education

Besides some high-profile announcements, such as an AI Centre of Excellence for education with an **allocation** of ₹500 crore, broadband connectivity for schools, the **expansion** of five third-generation IITs, and increased funding for Indian knowledge systems, Budget 2025 has promised higher allocations for education compared to last year's revised estimates. There was a 7% increase for higher education, although the actual expenditure for 2023-24 was 10% more than the 2025-26 Budget estimates. A key **challenge** in higher education **is** that the **ambitious** UGC **reforms**, modelled on **advanced** nations, **require** significant funding. **For instance**, introducing four-year degree programmes, allowing students to take courses across multiple institutions, implementing **bi-annual** admissions, and other structural changes demand **substantial** finances, which will **inevitably fall upon** State governments. However, Budget 2025 does not appear to adequately **address** these financial concerns. The **release** of the ASER 2024 report in the same week as the Union Budget **highlighted** gaps in India's school education system, particularly in foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN). While the report indicated that learning losses from the COVID-19 pandemic have been recovered, and, in some cases, FLN levels are at their highest ever, India still has some way to go before achieving full FLN, the 2026-27 target under the NIPUN Bharat scheme.

Compared to the 2024-25 revised estimates (RE), school education has been allocated an additional ₹11,000 crore, a 16% increase. However, as a percentage of the total Budget, this increase is only 0.12 percentage points, bringing the allocation to 1.55%. In higher education, the Budget **fraction** remains unchanged at 0.99%. While **institutions** such as Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan **continue** to receive significant funding, the increase does **reflect** higher inflows to States, which are the primary implementers of school education programmes. The Centre has been **keen on** fully implementing the National Education Policy (NEP), which **proposes** a 5+3+3+4 system that includes five years of early education up to Class 3. Early education is being prioritised as the key to achieving full FLN, but a critical gap remains: the two years before Class 1 are managed by underpaid anganwadi workers, who are already overburdened and often lack adequate training to **deliver on** FLN goals. A focused FLN **drive** is **pivotal** to achieving full FLN, a **prerequisite** for building a highly skilled workforce and **leveraging** India's **demographic dividend**. Over the next few years, depending on the progress made, the government must further strengthen school education investments to ensure India **meets** its full FLN target. **Time is of the essence.**

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Strengthen** (verb) – Reinforce, enhance, improve, fortify, bolster मजबूत करना
2. **Allocation** (noun) – Distribution, assignment, allotment, apportionment, disbursement आवंटन
3. **Expansion** (noun) – Growth, extension, enlargement, increase, development वृद्धि
4. **Ambitious** (adjective) – Aspiring, determined, bold, enterprising, goal-oriented महत्त्वाकांक्षी
5. **Advanced** (adjective) – Progressive, modern, developed, sophisticated, high-level आधुनिक
6. **For instance** (phrase) – For example, as an example, to illustrate, as a case in point उदाहरण के लिए
7. **Bi-annual** (adjective) – Twice a year, semi-annual, occurring every six months वर्ष में दो बार होने वाला
8. **Substantial** (adjective) – Significant, considerable, large, important, extensive काफी
9. **Inevitably** (adverb) – Unavoidably, necessarily, inescapably, certainly, without fail अनिवार्य रूप से
10. **Fall upon** (phrasal verb) – Be the responsibility of, come upon, rest upon, be assigned to के ऊपर आना, जिम्मेदारी होना
11. **Substantial** (adjective) – Large, meaningful, noteworthy, extensive, considerable महत्वपूर्ण
12. **Address** (verb) – Deal with, attend to, tackle, handle, resolve समाधान करना
13. **Highlight** (verb) – Emphasize, underline, stress, bring attention to, showcase ज़ोर देना
14. **Fraction** (noun) – Portion, small part, segment, division, percentage भाग
15. **Reflect** (verb) – Show, indicate, mirror, reveal, demonstrate दर्शाना
16. **Keen** (on) (adjective) – Interested in, eager, enthusiastic about, passionate about उत्सुक
17. **Propose** (verb) – Suggest, recommend, put forward, advocate, present प्रस्ताव रखना
18. **Deliver** (on) (verb) – Fulfill, achieve, accomplish, complete, execute पूरा करना
19. **Drive** (noun) – Initiative, campaign, movement, effort, push अभियान
20. **Pivotal** (adjective) – Crucial, essential, key, fundamental, central महत्वपूर्ण
21. **Prerequisite** (noun) – Requirement, necessity, essential, precondition, condition अनिवार्य शर्त

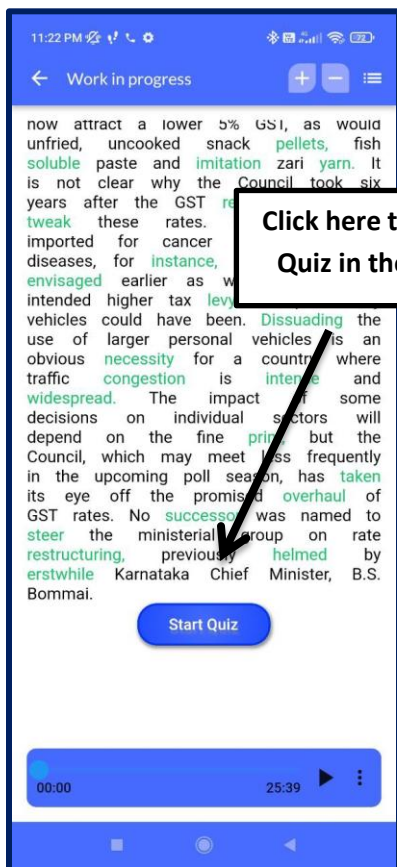
22. **Leverage** (verb) – Utilize, exploit, maximize, take advantage of, capitalize on
लाभ उठाना
23. **Demographic dividend** (noun) – the economic growth that occurs when the working-age population is larger than the non-working-age population
जनसांख्यिकीय लाभांश
24. **Meet** (verb) – Fulfill, achieve, satisfy, comply with, reach पूरा करना
25. **Time is of the essence** (phrase) – Urgent, time-sensitive, crucial, needing immediate action समय बहुत महत्वपूर्ण है

@mocks_wallah

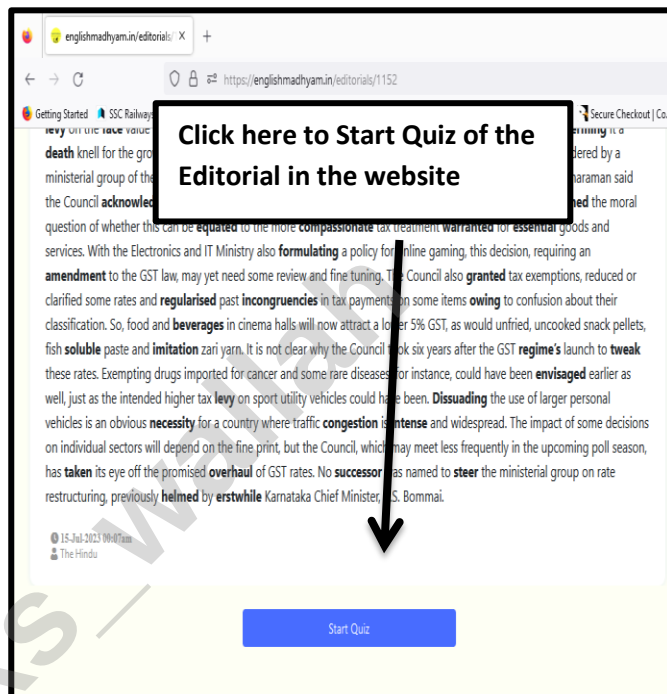
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Increased Education Budget** – Budget 2025 has allocated more funds for education compared to last year's revised estimates, with a 7% rise in higher education funding.
2. **High-Profile Announcements** – Key initiatives include an AI Centre of Excellence for Education (₹500 crore), broadband for schools, expansion of third-generation IITs, and increased funding for Indian knowledge systems.
3. **Higher Education Funding Challenges** – Despite budget increases, funding remains insufficient to support ambitious UGC reforms, including four-year degree programs, multi-institutional courses, and bi-annual admissions.
4. **State Governments' Financial Burden** – Many higher education reforms require substantial funding, much of which falls on State governments, raising concerns about financial feasibility.
5. **ASER 2024 Report Findings** – The report highlights learning recovery post-COVID-19, with foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) levels at their highest ever, but India is still short of its 2026-27 FLN target under the NIPUN Bharat scheme.
6. **Increase in School Education Allocation** – The Budget provides an additional ₹11,000 crore for school education, a 16% rise, but as a percentage of the total Budget, it increases only 0.12 percentage points (to 1.55%).
7. **Higher Education Allocation Stagnant** – The higher education budget fraction remains at 0.99%, indicating limited focus on expanding resources in this sector.
8. **State-Level Education Funding** – While Kendriya Vidyalayas receive substantial funding, a large portion of the increase is directed towards States, the primary implementers of school education programs.
9. **NEP 2020 Implementation** – The government is committed to fully implementing the National Education Policy (NEP), shifting to a 5+3+3+4 school structure, emphasizing early education.
10. **Early Childhood Education Challenges** – The first two years before Class 1 are handled by anganwadi workers, who are underpaid, overburdened, and lack adequate training to meet FLN goals effectively.
11. **The Critical Role of FLN** – Strengthening foundational literacy and numeracy is crucial for creating a skilled workforce and leveraging India's demographic dividend.
12. **Need for a Focused FLN Drive** – A well-structured FLN initiative is necessary to meet the full FLN target by 2026-27, ensuring that learning gaps do not persist.
13. **Budget Allocation Still Insufficient** – Despite increases, the overall percentage of education spending remains low, suggesting the need for further investment.
14. **Time-Sensitive Reforms** – Given India's large student population, delays in investment and policy execution could affect future workforce quality and economic growth.
15. **Call for Strengthened Investment** – The government must continue to expand education funding in the coming years, particularly in school education, to achieve its long-term FLN and workforce development goals.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



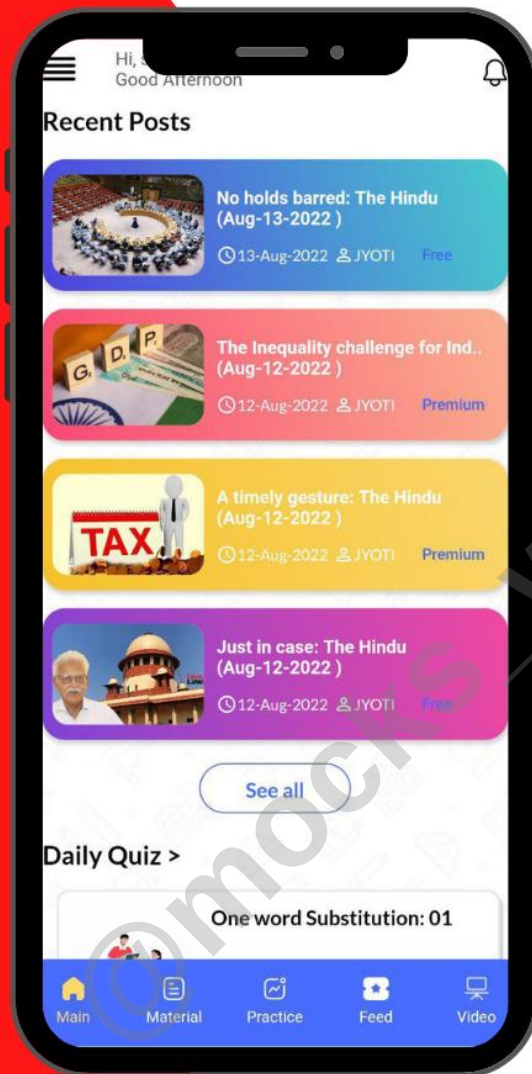
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